CIDS

TRAINING FRAMEWORK

1	**Consistency** Show Up	4x / week
2	**Intensity** Push Hard	<2 RIR
3	**Diet** Eat Right	1g/lb protein
4	**Sleep** Rest Well	7+ hrs / night

The rest is noise.

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CONSISTENCY

Why Consistency Is Pillar #1

Forget supplements. Forget meal timing. Forget the perfect program. None of it matters if you don't show up.

The 21-Day Myth — Debunked

Lally et al. (2010) found exercise habits take a median of **91 days** — not 21. Range: 18–254 days. There is no universal timeline for habit formation.

Why Frequency Matters

Schoenfeld et al. (2016) — training 2x/week beats 1x for hypertrophy even with equal volume. Showing up more often is itself a growth stimulus.

The Critical Window

Kaushal & Rhodes (2015) — attendance patterns in the first 4 weeks predict everything. People who exercise 1+ extra time per week in weeks 1–4 are **3x more likely** to stick with it long term.

> *"It's not what we do once in a while that shapes our lives, but what we do consistently."*
> *— Tony Robbins*

CONSISTENCY

The Science of Habit Formation

BJ Fogg's Behavior Model

B = MAP (Motivation × Ability × Prompt). All three must align for a behavior to occur. Lower the barrier, raise the prompt, and motivation becomes less critical.

Implementation Intentions

Gollwitzer (1997): "If [situation], then [behavior]" — goals completed **3x more often** when paired with a specific plan for when and where.

Habit Stacking

Clear (2018): "After [existing habit], I will [new habit]." This technique produced a **64% boost** in adoption by piggybacking on established neural pathways.

Identity-Based Habits

"I am a person who exercises" vs "I'm trying to exercise." Identity shift predicts persistence through obstacles. When the behavior becomes part of who you are, motivation becomes irrelevant.

Enjoyment Over Results

Affective judgments ($\beta = .13$) predict habit formation more strongly than outcomes. Focus on how exercise feels, not what it produces. If you enjoy it, you'll keep doing it.

The Habit Loop

Cue → Routine → Reward → Identity

CONSISTENCY

Your 6-Week Consistency Ramp-Up

Target: 4x per week for 6 consecutive weeks

Week 1–2: Build the Trigger

- Pick 4 days and block them in your calendar as non-negotiable
- Create your habit stack: "After [morning coffee / finishing work], I [put on gym clothes]"
- Start tiny: 20 minutes is enough. The goal is showing up, not performance
- Track only one thing: did you go? Yes/No checkmark
- Reward yourself immediately after (favorite podcast, smoothie, whatever)
- If you miss a day: it's fine. Lally et al. found missing one day doesn't disrupt habit formation

Week 3–4: Build Automaticity

- Continue 4x/week — this is the critical formation window
- Extend sessions to your target duration (30–45 min)
- Add one new element per week to maintain novelty (different exercise, class, or equipment)
- Start an achievement log: "4/4 this week" builds self-efficacy
- Find an accountability partner or group — 2.8x more likely to succeed (2025 meta-analysis of 42 studies)

Week 5–6: Lock It In

- At 42–49 days, research shows habit peaks for 48% of gym members
- Reduce decision-making: clothes laid out, bag packed, route automated
- Shift language: tell people "I exercise regularly" — public commitment strengthens habit
- Plan for disruptions: what happens when you travel, get sick, have a bad day?
- If it still doesn't feel automatic, stay in this phase — don't rush to Intensity

CONSISTENCY

Common Mistakes & Graduation Checklist

Common Mistakes

- Starting with 6 days/week (burns out by week 2)
- Focusing on the "perfect program" instead of just going
- Tracking performance metrics too early (track consistency, not weight/reps)
- Beating yourself up for missed days instead of returning the next day
- Trying to add diet/sleep changes simultaneously

Graduation Checklist

Move to Intensity when ALL boxes are checked:

- ☐ You've completed 4x/week for 6 consecutive weeks
- ☐ Going to the gym feels automatic, not like a decision
- ☐ Missing a session feels wrong, not like a relief
- ☐ You have a consistent time and trigger that works
- ☐ You can handle schedule disruptions without falling off

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2

INTENSITY

PUSH HARD

INTENSITY

Why Intensity Is Pillar #2

You're showing up. Good. Now the question is: are you actually working? Most people aren't.

The Hidden Reserve

Marcora (2014) found that when subjects reported complete exhaustion during cycling, their muscles could still produce **3x the power output** required. Your brain quits before your body does.

Beginners Massively Underestimate Capacity

Steele et al. (2017) — people underpredicted their capacity by **2.6–3.4 reps**. Zourdos et al. (2016) — novices underestimate by 4–5 reps. A beginner at perceived failure is really at RPE 6–7.

What Actually Drives Growth

Refalo et al. (2023) meta-analysis — training within 0–3 RIR is sufficient for hypertrophy. But most beginners train at 5–8 RIR without realizing it.

> *"I hate every minute of training. But I always remain consistent at it." — Muhammad Ali*

INTENSITY

The Science of Pushing Harder

Discomfort Tolerance Is Trainable

Regular exercise increases pain tolerance dose-dependently (PLOS ONE, 2023). It's the exposure to discomfort itself that builds tolerance. This isn't about genetics — it's about practice.

Fear vs Grit

Fear of pain is the strongest predictor of low tolerance. Grit is the strongest predictor of high tolerance (Tesarz et al., 2020). Reframe discomfort as progress, not danger.

Self-Talk Works

Blanchfield et al. (2014) — motivational self-talk improved endurance by **18%** and reduced perceived effort. Second-person ("You've got this") works better than first-person.

Association > Dissociation

At high intensity, focusing INTO the sensation (association) enables greater output than distracting yourself. Stay with the discomfort — it's where the growth is.

RIR Scale — Reps In Reserve

RIR 0

Could not do another rep (failure)

RIR 1

Could maybe do 1 more

RIR 2

Could do 2 more

RIR 3+

Too easy — not in the growth zone

INTENSITY

Your 4-Week Intensity Ramp-Up

Target: Train at 0–2 RIR on all working sets

Week 1: Calibration

- On the LAST set of each exercise, go to actual failure (safely, with a spotter or on machines)
- Count how many reps beyond your normal stopping point — this reveals your hidden reserve (typically 3–8 reps)
- Record your estimated RIR vs actual for each exercise
- Continue 4x/week schedule from Phase 1
- This week is data collection, not ego — use moderate weights

Week 2: Close the Gap (target 2–3 RIR)

- Use Week 1 data to recalibrate — add reps or weight to reach the 2–3 RIR zone
- Begin motivational self-talk on the final 3–5 reps ("You've got this, two more")
- Phone stays in the bag during all working sets
- Continue last-set-to-failure on one exercise for ongoing calibration

Week 3: Normalize Discomfort (target 1–2 RIR)

- Increase load ~5% on compound lifts OR add 1–2 reps per set
- At least 2 sets per exercise should finish at 1 RIR
- Practice associative focus: stay with the sensation instead of escaping it
- Pre-commit to rep targets BEFORE the set — no mid-set negotiation
- Use short cue words per rep: "Drive," "Push," "One more"

Week 4: Full Intensity (target 0–2 RIR)

- Working sets: ~30% to failure, ~50% at 1 RIR, ~20% at 2 RIR
- Self-talk and associative strategies should feel habitual
- What felt like RPE 9 in Week 1 should feel like 7–8 at the same load — your tolerance has adapted
- **Plan a deload in Week 5** (reduce volume 40–50%, keep intensity moderate)

INTENSITY

Common Mistakes & Graduation Checklist

Common Mistakes

- Ego lifting — heavy weight with bad form is not intensity, it's injury risk
- Junk volume — 20 sets at RIR 5 is worse than 10 sets at RIR 1–2
- Not tracking weights/reps — you can't know if you're progressing without data
- Skipping deloads — planned recovery prevents unplanned recovery (injury)
- Confusing soreness with effectiveness — DOMS ≠ growth stimulus

Graduation Checklist

Move to Diet when ALL boxes are checked:

- ☐ You consistently train at 0–2 RIR on working sets
- ☐ You can accurately estimate your RIR within 1–2 reps
- ☐ You log your weights and reps every session
- ☐ Discomfort during hard sets feels manageable, not terrifying
- ☐ You've completed at least one deload week

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DIET

Why Diet Is Pillar #3

You're consistent and training hard. Now give your body what it needs to actually build. The answer is simpler than the fitness industry wants you to believe: protein.

Not a Diet Plan — A Protein Plan

Total daily protein is the single strongest predictor of muscle gains. Everything else (timing, distribution, supplements) is secondary.

The Number: 1g per pound of bodyweight (2g/kg) per day

Nunes et al. (2022) — 1.6–2.2g/kg per day optimizes hypertrophy. We simplify to 1g per pound.

Timing Myth — Busted

Schoenfeld, Aragon & Krieger (2013) meta-analyzed 23 studies — after controlling for total protein, timing effects on strength and hypertrophy disappeared entirely.

The Definitive Meta-Analysis

Morton et al. (2018, 49 studies, 1,863 participants) confirmed: benefits plateau at ~1.6g/kg/day. Hit your total daily number and you're covered.

> *"You don't do things right once in a while. You do things right all the time." — Vince Lombardi*

DIET

The Science of Protein

Per-Meal MPS Threshold

~0.4g/kg per meal across 3–4 meals. Mamerow et al. (2014) found even distribution produces **25% higher** 24-hour MPS than skewing toward dinner.

The Leucine Trigger

~2–3g leucine per meal activates MPS (roughly 25–30g quality protein). Zaromskyte et al. (2021) — more of a dose-response curve than a hard threshold for younger adults.

Practical Rule: 30g+ protein from quality sources per meal

Quick Reference — Daily Protein Targets

Your Weight	Daily Protein Target	Per Meal (4 meals)
130 lb / 59 kg	130g	~33g
150 lb / 68 kg	150g	~38g
180 lb / 82 kg	180g	~45g
200 lb / 91 kg	200g	~50g

Simple Protein Sources

Chicken breast (6 oz)	54g	Eggs (3 large)	18g
Greek yogurt (1 cup)	20g	Whey protein (1 scoop)	25g
Tuna (1 can)	30g	Cottage cheese (1 cup)	28g
Ground beef (6 oz)	42g	Tofu, firm (1 cup)	20g

DIET

Your 4-Week Protein Ramp-Up

Target: Hit your daily protein goal 5 out of 7 days

Week 1: Awareness

- Track everything you eat for 7 days (MyFitnessPal, notebook, photos — whatever works)
- Don't change anything — just observe
- At the end of the week, calculate your average daily protein
- Most beginners discover they're eating 60–80g when they need 150–180g
- The gap is your roadmap

Week 2: Fix Breakfast

- Breakfast is the biggest protein gap for most people (toast, cereal, fruit = near-zero protein)
- New default: 30–40g protein at breakfast (eggs + Greek yogurt, protein shake + oats, etc.)
- Pick 2–3 breakfast options and rotate — don't overthink it
- Continue tracking protein only (not calories, carbs, or fat)

Week 3: Fix Lunch + Dinner

- Anchor every meal around a protein source FIRST, then add everything else
- Simple rule: palm-sized portion of protein at every meal = roughly 30g
- Add a 4th protein hit if needed (pre-bed Greek yogurt, protein shake, cottage cheese)
- You should be hitting your target most days now

Week 4: Fine-Tune and Automate

- Review your tracking: hitting 5/7 days at target?
- Identify your go-to meals — the 5–6 meals you rotate through that always hit protein
- Start meal prepping: 2 hours on Sunday saves you all week
- Stop obsessive tracking — you know your defaults now, trust them
- Only re-track if you change your routine significantly

DIET

Common Mistakes & Graduation Checklist

Common Mistakes

- Overthinking it — protein first, the rest follows
- Relying entirely on shakes (whole food protein is more satiating)
- Undercounting: not weighing/measuring initially, then overestimating
- Trying to overhaul everything at once (just fix protein, not your entire diet)
- Skipping meals then trying to get 100g at dinner

Graduation Checklist

Move to Sleep when ALL boxes are checked:

- ☐ You know your daily protein target and can hit it 5/7 days
- ☐ You have 5–6 default meals that reliably hit 30g+ protein each
- ☐ You can eyeball a protein portion without weighing it
- ☐ Breakfast includes 30g+ protein as a habit
- ☐ You've maintained this for at least 3 consecutive weeks

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SLEEP

Why Sleep Is Pillar #4

You're doing the work. You're eating right. Now let your body do what it does best: rebuild. Muscle isn't built in the gym — it's built while you sleep.

Sleep Deprivation Impairs Muscle Growth

Lamon et al. (2021) — one night of sleep deprivation reduced MPS by **18%**, increased cortisol 21%, decreased testosterone 24%. Sleep loss directly attacks the biology of muscle growth.

Sleep Extension Boosts Performance

Mah et al. (2011) — Stanford basketball players who extended sleep to 10 hours improved sprint times ~5%, free-throw accuracy +9%. More sleep = better performance, full stop.

Regularity Beats Duration

Windred et al. (2024, 60,977 participants) — sleep **regularity** was a stronger predictor of all-cause mortality than sleep duration. Regular sleepers had 20–48% lower mortality risk.

> *"Hard work, dedication, and discipline separate the best from the rest." — Kobe Bryant*

SLEEP

The Science of Recovery Sleep

Deep Sleep (N3)

~70% of daily growth hormone is secreted during deep sleep (Dattilo et al., 2011). Deep sleep dominates the first half of the night — early bedtime matters.

REM Sleep

Dominates the second half of the night. Cutting sleep short disproportionately kills REM. UC Berkeley (2025): Both REM and non-REM contribute to GH release through different mechanisms — you need both.

Pre-Sleep Protein Works

Res et al. (2012) — 40g casein before bed increases overnight MPS. Your body actively builds muscle while you sleep IF you've given it protein.

What Actually Works (Research-Ranked)

1. Consistent schedule (strongest evidence) — Windred et al. (2024). Regularity is the #1 factor.

2. Caffeine cutoff (strongest for sleep quality) — Gardiner et al. (2023) meta-analysis: caffeine reduces total sleep 45 min, deep sleep 11 min. Cutoff: **8.8 hours** before bed for standard coffee, **13.2 hours** for pre-workout.

3. Room temperature (moderate evidence) — 18–21°C / 65–70°F optimal.

4. Blue light blocking (mixed evidence) — trend toward benefit but didn't reach significance in meta-analysis. Useful but not transformative.

SLEEP

Your 4-Week Sleep Ramp-Up

Target: 7+ hours of consistent, quality sleep per night

Week 1: Assess + Caffeine Fix

- Track your sleep for 7 days: what time you go to bed, what time you wake up, how you feel (1–5)
- Calculate your average — most people discover they're getting 5.5–6.5 hours
- Implement caffeine cutoff: no coffee/pre-workout after 2pm (or 9 hours before target bedtime)
- This one change alone can add 30–45 minutes of quality sleep
- Don't change anything else yet

Week 2: Anchor Your Wake Time

- Pick a wake time and stick to it 7 days a week — yes, weekends too
- This is more important than bedtime (Windred et al., 2024)
- Your body will naturally start getting tired earlier once the wake time is consistent
- Continue tracking sleep hours and quality rating
- Expect the first few days to feel rough if your weekend wake time was 2+ hours later

Week 3: Optimize Environment + Set Bedtime

- Set bedroom temperature to 18–21°C / 65–70°F
- Blackout curtains or sleep mask
- Set a consistent bedtime that gives you 7.5–8 hours before your anchor wake time
- Phone on charger in another room by 30 minutes before bedtime
- Optional: 30–40g casein protein before bed (Res et al., 2012)

Week 4: Fine-Tune

- Review your tracking: averaging 7+ hours? Quality rating improving?
- Address remaining disruptors: alcohol (even 1–2 drinks reduces deep sleep), late heavy meals, blue light
- If you're lying awake >20 minutes, get up and do something boring — don't scroll
- Your sleep should feel noticeably better than Week 1
- This is now maintenance — protect these habits the way you protect your gym schedule

SLEEP

Common Mistakes & Graduation Checklist

Common Mistakes

- Sleeping in on weekends (destroys regularity — the single most important factor)
- "I'll sleep when I'm dead" mentality (sleep deprivation literally reduces muscle growth by 18%)
- Relying on supplements (melatonin masks the problem, doesn't fix it)
- Screen time in bed (the bed is for sleep, not scrolling)
- Ignoring caffeine timing (that 3pm coffee is costing you 45 minutes of sleep)

Graduation Checklist

You've completed CIDS when ALL boxes are checked:

- ☐ You average 7+ hours of sleep per night
- ☐ Your bedtime and wake time are consistent within 30 minutes, 7 days/week
- ☐ You fall asleep within 15–20 minutes of lying down
- ☐ You wake up feeling functional without hitting snooze
- ☐ You've maintained this for at least 3 consecutive weeks

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Your CIDS Timeline

The full journey — 18 weeks to build all four pillars

WEEKS 1–6

Consistency — Show Up

Build the gym habit. 4x per week, every week. Start small. Track attendance only. Don't optimize anything yet — just show up until it's automatic.

WEEKS 7–10

Intensity — Push Hard

Calibrate your effort. Learn to train at 0–2 RIR. Close the gap between perceived and actual failure. Build discomfort tolerance through practice.

WEEKS 11–14

Diet — Eat Right

Nail your protein. Track for a week, fix breakfast, fix lunch and dinner, then automate. 1g per pound, 30g+ per meal, 5/7 days on target.

WEEKS 15–18

Sleep — Rest Well

Optimize recovery. Cut caffeine early, anchor your wake time, set your environment, fine-tune. 7+ hours, consistent schedule, 7 days a week.

After Week 18, you have all four pillars in place.

Now it's maintenance. The rest is noise.

Key principle: Don't skip ahead. Each pillar builds on the last. Consistency before intensity. Intensity before diet. Diet before sleep.

Quick Reference Card

Screenshot this page or print it

Pillar	Target	Key Rule
Consistency	4x / week	Show up before you optimize
Intensity	<2 RIR	Your brain quits before your body does
Diet	1g/lb / 2g/kg protein	Total daily protein is all that matters
Sleep	7+ hrs / night	Regularity beats duration

The rest is noise.

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Full citations for all research cited in this guide

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